her for all these reasons of big and little consequence. They hated her pale snow face, her waiting silence, her thinness, and her possible future.

"Get away!" The boy gave her another push. "What're you waiting for?"

Then, for the first time, she turned and looked at him. And what she was waiting for was in her eyes.

"Well, don't wait around here !" cried the boy **savagely**. "You won't see nothing!"

Her lips moved.

"Nothing!" he cried. "It was all a joke,wasn't it?" He turned to the other children.

"Nothing's happening today. *Is* it ?"

They all blinked at him and then, understanding, laughed and shook their heads.

"Nothing, nothing !"

"Oh, but," Margot **whispered**, her eyes helpless. "But this is the day, the scientists **predict**, they say, they *know*, the sun…"

"All a joke!" said the boy, and seized her roughly. "Hey, everyone, let's put her in a closet before the teacher comes!"

"No," said Margot, falling back.

They **surged** about her, caught her up and bore her, protesting, and then pleading, and then crying, back into a tunnel, a room, a closet, where they **slammed** and locked the door. They stood looking at the door and saw it **tremble** from her beating and throwing herself against it. They heard her **muffled** cries. Then, smiling, they turned and went out and back down the tunnel, just as the teacher arrived.

"Ready, children ?" She glanced at her watch.

"Yes!" said everyone.

"Are we all here ?"

"Yes!"

The rain slacked still more.

They crowded to the huge door.

The rain stopped.

It was as if, in the midst of a film concerning an **avalanche**, a tornado, a hurricane, a volcanic eruption, something had, first, gone wrong with the sound apparatus, thus muffling and finally cutting off all noise, all of the blasts and **repercussions** and thunders, and then, second, ripped the film from the projector and inserted in its place a beautiful tropical slide which did not move or had a **tremor**. The world ground to a standstill. The silence was so immense and unbelievable that you felt your ears had been stuffed or you had lost your hearing altogether. The children put their hands to their ears. They stood apart. The door slid back and the smell of the silent, waiting world came in to them.

The sun came out.

It was the colour of flaming bronze and it was very large. And the sky around it was a blazing blue tile colour. And the jungle burned with sunlight as the

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